



R. V. MOORTHY

top to find his well-timed run, setting him through on goal and *thud*!

Except, it wasn't him, but Rahim Ali, who was on the end of the chance, which he missed. For Rahim, that could have been the beginning of his making. A goal on Chhetri's last day in an India shirt would have temporarily answered the 'Who after Chhetri?' question, but it wasn't to be.

On a personal note, it was a game to forget for Chhetri. **He was peripheral in the first forty-five minutes as his teammates failed to release the ball early to meet his runs, leaving him to chase shadows.** He played as a striker, as a No. 10, and as a striker again, but it seemed to be one of those days where no teammates could find him with the ball.

It's unfortunate that Chhetri's final stretch with the national team also coincided with the team's unwanted record of 645 minutes without a goal from open play.

When his teammates collapsed around him, Chhetri stood still near

the centre circle, head bowed down. All he wanted was to get India close to the finish line of making the third round of the qualifiers in Kolkata, in front of the home fans. But in the end, there was no one to take India through to a win or carry Chhetri on their shoulders.

The veteran of 151 caps and 94 international goals, one of the greatest footballers India has ever produced, made a teary lap of honour around the stadium to applause from the faithful. Chhetri's mother, Sushila, looked on in tears next to his father, Kharga. There were tears everywhere.

The guard of honour hit home the hardest. His teammates lined up on

each side from the pitch towards the dressing room tunnel. As Chhetri stood at the start of the line, he sobbed inconsolably with his hands covering his face, knowing full well he would never again pull on an India shirt.

Till the very end, Chhetri was all heart, and his farewell speech was no different. "For everyone who came for the game, everyone who has watched me for 19 years, thank you. These 19 years would not have been possible without you all, and I genuinely mean it. I want to speak from my heart, *shobai bhalo thakben, khushi thakben* (everyone stay well, stay happy)," India's Sonar Sunil signed off.

TWO TIFOS IN THE NORTH STAND SUMMED UP CHHETRI PERFECTLY, DEPICTING HIM CARRYING INDIAN FOOTBALL ON HIS BACK, JUST AS HE HAD DONE FOR 19 YEARS